Inflation, Priced in Roti Bakar

The roti bakar used to cost RM2.50. I know this the way you know the smell of rain, not because I wrote it down but because my mornings kept a ledger my brain never asked to keep. Last week the same plate, same stall, same uncle who has toasted bread on that corner since before I could reach the counter, cost RM4.00.

Nobody announced it. There was no press release. The price just moved one quiet morning, the way prices do now, and everyone at the stall accepted it the way you accept weather.

That little plate of toast is the most honest economic indicator I own.

The official numbers tell a calmer story. Malaysia's headline inflation sits around [VERIFY: latest CPI figure and source], a number so well-behaved it almost sounds like good news. Central bankers cite it with straight faces. Economists nod. And then you go and buy breakfast, and the numbers on the menu and the numbers in the report seem to describe two different countries.

Both numbers are real. That is the strange part. The official basket measures hundreds of items, weighted and smoothed

and seasonally adjusted until the sharp edges come off. Your life measures about twenty items, bought weekly, with no smoothing at all. Food, transport, rent. The things you cannot postpone are exactly the things that moved first.

This is why inflation arguments go nowhere. One side waves the index. The other side waves the receipt. They are both holding evidence, and they are both missing the point, which is that averages are a polite fiction. Nobody lives in an average. You live in your own basket, and your basket has opinions.

There is also the quieter trick, the one nobody prices: shrinkflation. The packet looks the same. The price looks the same. But the contents went from 500 grams to 420, and the manufacturer is betting you will notice the price tag and not the weight. It is inflation wearing a costume, and it works because humans compare prices, not quantities. Our brains were not built for unit economics at the shelf.

None of this means the official statistics are lying. Measuring inflation across an entire economy is genuinely hard, and the people who do it are not inventing numbers in a back room. But a single number cannot carry the texture of what it feels like to watch your morning get 60 percent more expensive in slow motion [VERIFY: compute actual % from verified prices].

Here is the part that interests me as someone who watches markets for a living. Asset prices recovered. Property in the

right neighborhoods kept climbing [VERIFY: representative figure and source]. The stock market found new highs to admire. But the wage slip at the bottom of the economy moved like it was stuck in traffic. Inflation, it turns out, is not one tax. It is two: a mild one on people who own assets, and a steep one on people who only own their mornings.

The uncle at the stall understands this better than most economists I read. He did not raise his price because of monetary theory. He raised it because butter costs more, because the gas for the grill costs more, because the rent on the corner went up. His inflation has names and faces. The index has decimals.

I still go to the same stall. The roti bakar is still good. But I eat it now with a small private ritual: I remember the old price, I pay the new one, and I think about how much of economics is just this, repeated a few billion times. Someone, somewhere, quietly rewriting a menu.

The bill always arrives. Sometimes it just arrives as toast.